

Thought Partner

A good prompt gets you an answer in one shot. Thought partnership is for the messier work, where one answer isn't the end of the conversation.

AI can help you explore ideas, pressure-test your thinking, and get unstuck. But the thinking still has to be yours. The best use of AI as a thought partner is when **you** drive the conversation and **you** make the decisions.

WATCH: THINKING TOGETHER

Working a summer-plans problem with AI

START VAGUE

I don't know what to do this summer.

That's a pretty open canvas. A few things would help me think through this with you. Are you looking to make money, build something for college apps, try something new, or some combination? And is there anything you're already drawn to, even vaguely?

NARROW THE GOAL

Probably both. Money would be good but I also want something that looks decent for college. I'm into tech but I don't actually know how to code.

That's a useful combination. Tech-adjacent doesn't have to mean coding. There's a whole layer of work that sits between the technical and the human side. Things like research assistance, content for tech companies, product testing, social media for startups, or even just helping a small business get set up with AI tools. Any of those directions feel interesting, or does something else come to mind?

PICK A DIRECTION

The AI tools thing actually sounds interesting. I've been using Claude a lot lately and I kind of get how it works.

That's actually a real edge right now: most people your age are using AI but very few understand it well enough to teach it or implement it for others. You could position yourself as someone who helps small local businesses figure out where AI fits in their workflow. It doesn't require coding. It requires exactly what you're already building: understanding the tool and how to use it well. Want to think through what that could actually look like?

NAME THE OBSTACLE

Yeah but I wouldn't even know how to get a business to take me seriously. I'm 17.

17 is actually part of the pitch, not a problem with it. You lead with that: 'I'm a student who's been studying AI tools seriously and I want to help one local business implement them this summer for free or low cost in exchange for a reference.' Free is a door opener. One good outcome becomes your portfolio. Which kind of business do you think you'd actually want to work with?

GET PUSHED BACK

OK, so my plan is to email every business in town at once. That way at least somebody says yes.

I'd push back on that plan. Fifty copy-paste emails from a student nobody knows will mostly get deleted, and you can't write a specific pitch for fifty places at once. What makes you credible is specificity: knowing their business, naming a gap you actually noticed. One well-researched pitch beats fifty generic ones. Does that change which businesses you'd start with?

TURN IT INTO ACTION

Probably a restaurant or a small retail store. Something local I could actually walk into.

Perfect. Walk-in businesses are ideal because the owner is usually right there. Here's a starting move: identify 3-5 local spots you already go to, research whether they have a Google Business profile, active social media, and whether they respond to reviews. Those gaps are your opening. You're not selling AI. You're solving a specific problem they already have. Want help drafting what you'd actually say when you walk in?

THE TAKEAWAY

AI explored. You decided.

It opened up the options, pushed back on a weak plan, and poked at the obstacles, but every choice stayed yours. A good thought partner widens your thinking without taking it over.

FIVE THOUGHT-PARTNER PROMPTS TO COPY

The conversation above used a few specific moves. Here are five worth keeping:

- "Ask me five questions before giving advice."
- "Challenge my assumption."
- "Give me three possible explanations."
- "What would a skeptical reader say?"
- "Where might I be fooling myself?"

Different problems take different moves. The pattern is the same: you stay in the work, AI helps you see what you're not seeing.

Think with it, not for you.

It's a partner, not the author.